Delhi's poor air quality after Diwali is because of Biomass burning, not fireworks: IIT Delhi Study

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The study titled 'Chemical speciation and source apportionment of ambient PM2.5 in New Delhi before, during, and after the Diwali fireworks' led by IIT Delhi researchers sheds light on the pollution sources impacting the ambient air quality in the capital before, during, and after Diwali.



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The Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Delhi study has revealed that the Diwali festivities in the capital city often coincide with the crop harvesting season and thus resulting in stubble burning, which in turn effect the air quality severely. These events together ofter make it difficult to ascertain the impact of either of the two on ambient air pollution in the capital.

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The researchers have also found out that the metal content in PM2.5 levels rose by 1100 per cent, and the fireworks alone accounted for 95 per cent of the metal PM2.5 during Diwali. "However, the impact of the fireworks plummets within around 12 hours following Diwali", said Chirag Manchanda, the lead author of this study.

"Both stubble burning and increased heating requirements of the region in winters drive the biomass burning activity", said Professor Vikram Singh, Department of Chemical Engineering, IIT Delhi. The study thus concludes that the biomass

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burning emissions rather than the fireworks drive the poor air quality in Delhi during the days following Diwali.

“The result of this study provides crucial insights into a topic of long-standing debate and concern between air quality experts and policymakers committed to alleviating the extreme air pollution events in the capital of Delhi following Diwali,” said the principal investigator Prof Mayank Kumar, Department of Mechanical Engineering, IIT Delhi.

The researchers have found that biomass burning-related emissions rise steeply in the days following Diwali, with average levels almost rising by order of ~2 compared to the pre-Diwali concentration.

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